A beginner's guide to Pixate

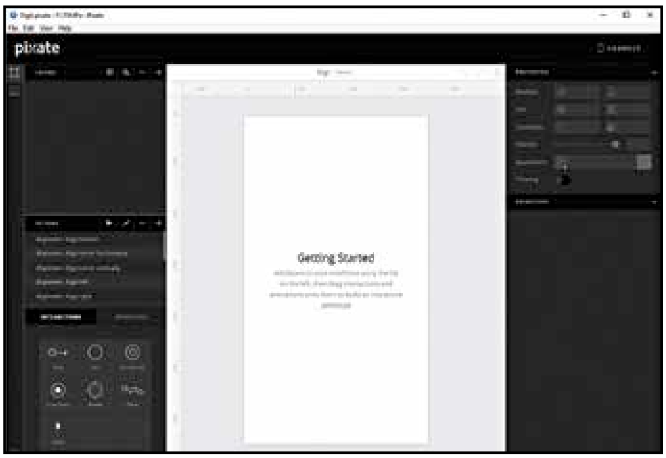
>> One of the hottest prototyping tools – Pixate is really simple to work with > by Mithun Mohandas

Pixate is what you'd call an app prototyping tool and they are a dime a dozen. For the uninitiated, prototyping is how you generate mockups or prototypes of applications without the need to know programming languages such as Objective C or Java. So every other person can easily bring their ideas to life and learn more about UX at the same time. Instead of having to hire a consultant from the get go, you can work out a good amount of the mechanics and create a prototype that's just short of being truly native to a platform. What's even better is that Pixate Studio is free and the company has been purchased by Google as part of their effort to develop new design and prototyping tools. This could very well mean that you might find Pixate becoming part of Android Studio.

There are plenty of prototyping tools but there's always been a tradeoff between speed and quality. Pixate is quick and allows you to create prototypes rapidly without any tradeoff, as it will be apparent soon enough. Let's get you started on some basic actions that can be performed using this nifty tool.

User Interface

If you've ever used an IDE before, you'll quickly feel at home when you run Pixate for the first time. Take a look at the image below. This is the first thing you'll see when you fire up Pixate. On the very left of the window are two tabs, of which the first tab opens up the 'layers' panel that you see here and the second tab opens up the 'assets' panel. Assets are basically images of all the UI elements in different stages. For example, if you were to drag a menu bar around and wanted the bar to go out of focus then you'd create two images, one with the menu bar looking crisp and the other with the menu bar all faded out. You'd then transition between these two assets based on a trigger event. In this case, the dragging action would be the trigger.



A fairly simply and easy to navigate UI

The 'layers' panel is where you organise all the different layers of your interface. Almost everyone has used some sort of image editing software or apps such as Photoshop, Gimp, Pixlr etc., so the concept is quite clear.

Right beneath the 'layers' panel lies the 'actions' panel from where you can pick different animations to be applied to transitions. On the top right lies the properties pane that allows you to modify layer parameters like size, position, opacity etc. And right below the 'properties' panel lies the 'animations' panel, where you can define the animations for the selected layer. The centre houses the workspace where all the magic happens.

A few pointers

Before you begin, you need to list out all the features you want from your app and generate assets for the device that you'll be working on. Resolution and pixel density should be kept in mind while generating these assets. Both Android (https://developer.android.com/guide/practices/screens_support.html) and iOS (https://developer.apple.com/library/ios/documentation/UserExperience/Conceptual/MobileHIG/) have guidelines for designing apps which need to be followed to the letter. The Apple App Store is a lot more stringent when it comes to QC and it wouldn't be a surprise if your app were to be rejected for flouting guidelines.

Get the app

Prototyping on Pixate happens in real time with all your changes being updated onto the app as soon as they're made, so you can reduce the time spent on prototyping your app. Simply download the app from the Play Store or the App Store and sync it with your PC / Mac.

Begin prototyping

Start off by importing all your assets into the assets panel. Always make an image which would be representative of how your final app looks like and use that as a base layer to figure out where to place all the individual elements of the UI.

Adding animations

Let's start off by dragging an image (let's call it Button.jpg) onto the screen and giving it the properties of a button. Tap sets into motion an animation. So you can simply drag the 'tap' interaction from the interaction menu and drop it onto the image within the workspace, or drop it onto the specific layer in the layer panel.

There should now appear a new property in the panel that indicates that a Tap action has been added to the layer. Now you need to drag and drop another image (let's call this one Screen.jpg) onto the workspace. Reorder the layers so that the Button.jpg layer is on top of the Screen.